

THE FOURSOME: 1. Suresh Nanda, 2. Ashutosh Verma, 3. Sanjeev Nanda, 4. Bipin Shah



THE BARAK BACKFIRE

CBI nabs India's biggest arms agent in a seven-year-old case involving the purchase of Barak missiles even as the navy gets ready to bear the brunt of the scandal on its defence preparedness

■ **By Sandeep Unnithan**

For an arms dealer who allegedly brokered several high-profile deals including those to equip Indian warships with Barak missiles and was allegedly involved in a multi-billion dollar deal to buy the aircraft carrier *Admiral Gorshkov*, the moment was decidedly anticlimactic. A CBI team swooped on Suresh Nanda and his son Sanjeev in a suburban five-star hotel in Mumbai and caught them red-handed reportedly while trying to

bribe an income-tax official to cover up a tax investigation.

Suresh, who quit the navy as a lieutenant commander in the late 1960s to become an arms agent, was already under the CBI gaze for his involvement in the Rs 1,125-crore Barak case. Desperate, he made another mistake by trying to bribe Ashutosh Verma, deputy director of I-T (investigations), with Rs 10 crore to keep under wraps the report of a series of I-T raids on his premises in 2007 which unearthed incriminating evidence of his involve-

ment in the Barak case.

CBI has booked the four accused—the Nandas, their chartered accountant Bipin Shah and Verma—under Section 120B accusing them of hatching a criminal conspiracy and remanded them to custody. It was the newest episode in the seven-year-long case following procurement of six anti-missile defence systems (AMD) from Israel. Nandas' lawyer has denied the bribery charges and said they were present only for a business meeting. The bribery aspect has given CBI a han-